

empty during and after succession, the chances of a blow-up are much higher.

THE MATRIARCH OF THE ROTHSCHILDS

My mother's love for me was so great I have worked hard to justify it.

—Marc Chagall

We all know how Mayer Rothschild made a lot of money in banking and how he sent his five sons all over Europe to build the family banking empire. But why were the sons willing and able to take up the burden? Turns out that the old saying “For the hand that rocks the cradle is the hand that rules the world” is true.

The matriarch of the Rothschild dynasty was a remarkable woman named Gutle Schnaper. She bore her 19 children, of whom 10 survived to maturity. She gave birth virtually every year from 1771, the year after her marriage, through the next 20 years.

She raised this prodigious family in an overcrowded alley in the Jewish ghetto of Frankfurt. Three thousand people were packed into this area, which was designed for 500, on a street called Jews' Street. The densely packed houses created a fire hazard, and the area burned down three times over.

They were second-class citizens, not allowed to leave Jews' Street after dark, on Sundays, or on Christian holidays. They were forbidden from owning land or farming, or trading in silk, wine, fruit, or weapons. They had to pay special tolls when they traveled. They weren't allowed to enter taverns, inns, or city parks.

In the 1780s, the average mortality rate among Jews was 58 percent higher than among Gentiles.

A traveler in 1795 observed how “most of the people among the Frankfurt Jews, even those who are in the blooming years of their life, look like the walking dead. . . . Their deathly pale appearance sets them apart from all the other inhabitants in the most depressing way.”²